

MOUNT YOUR CAREER FIRMLY IN SMT

From handling the process line at the manufacturing plant to dealing with maintenance and troubleshooting of SMT machines, the SMT field offers many opportunities for skilled professionals

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Traditional soldering, or rather through-hole soldering, is out.

This assembly process had once predominated electronics manufacturing. Major manufacturers are now looking for a more sophisticated alternative. All those manufacturing players who were affected due to low productivity or quality issues associated with through-hole soldering are now finding a quantum of solace in surface-mount technology (SMT). Moreover, SMT is environment-friendly due to the possibility of lead-free mode of operation.

If you are an entry-level electronics professional, it's a good opportunity to make your career recession-proof by

adopting the SMT path. Let's delve a little deeper into the sector and figure out what skills your employer may expect from you.

Know the field

Open any electronic gadget and observe minutely the circuit. You will see some tiny components mounted on a board. In most cases, these are surface-mount devices (SMDs) assembled using the SMT.

The SMT market in India will grow proportionally with the growth of electronics manufacturing dominating all other production technologies. The electronics consumption in India has over the years seen phenomenal growth and is now valued at over \$300 billion with an estimated growth

rate of 23 per cent. The increased investments by global EMS (electronic manufacturing services) players in anticipation of the tremendous electronics demand will further accelerate the market size.

Ernst & Young projects that India can target an EMS share of one per cent in North America, two per cent in Western Europe, one per cent in Asia and five per cent in the rest of the world. It could account for 2.2 per cent of the worldwide electronics EMS market of \$497 billion by 2010, which works out to \$11 billion.

Market players at the top

The SMT players can be categorised into SMT production equipment suppliers and SMT equipment users for manufacturing. Juki, Panasonic, American Tec, Tyco and CDIL are the prominent names in the SMT field. EMS players are also major stakeholders.

Considering the skilled manpower of India, India is being seen as the logical outsourcing destination. Original equipment manufacturers such as LG Electronics, Nokia and Samsung already have their footprints in India. Moreover, some large EMS providers operating in India at present range from global participants such as Solecron, Flextronics International, Jabil Circuit, Celestica and Foxconn Technology to local firms like Deltron, TVS Electronics (TVS-E), D-Link and Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL).

Telecom equipment are in demand. So companies like Nokia, Siemens and Bharti Teletel are the potential recruiters of SMT profession-

